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A lady in front of Intel Magic Mirror (Credit: <http://newsroom.intel.com>)

a brief form that requires details like your age, gender, income, occupation, email ID, etc. A few days later you receive an email from the store informing you about some attractive offers on shoes. Till now you have been buying only shoe accessories such as socks and shoe polish, among other things. This is data mining at work.

Big Data, a term much in vogue today, refers to the deployment of huge amounts of information to make businesses more efficient and responsive to clients and customers. Data is collected and mined in a number of sectors, more so, retail, telecom and finance. However, the retail sector has the highest level of interaction with a huge volume of customers from different walks of life and, hence, retailers are very interested in understanding their customers as closely as they possibly can.

Imagine you login to your favourite e-commerce site to buy, say, a handset, and shortlist one and put it in your virtual shopping cart. However, you read customer reviews and end up changing your mind. You then discover that every online store that you visit features an ad for that very handset. This happens as online retailers can give you a virtual ID number and track your journey from site to site, and purchase targeted ads for products they know are of interest to you—this is known as ghost marketing.

A firm has developed a computer program that enables a store's secu-

rity cameras to give the management different types of information about how consumers interacted inside the shopping area. It tells precisely the number of customers present inside a given store at a time, areas of the store explored by them and specific products on which shoppers spent appreciable time. The software can integrate this information with other factors such as staffing levels, weather, product variety and placement to conclude what makes sales happen.

In future, computer programs will allow video cameras to understand a customer's gender, interpret customers' facial expressions and other gestures to help retailers understand why someone did or did not buy a given product.

Endpoint

Retailers are starting to acknowledge the role of IT as an enabler. Basically, it can speed up processes and deliver cost-saving benefits to companies. Technology as well as buying behaviour is evolving at breakneck speed and retailers who wait for others to drive touch-point adoption will find themselves to be losers.

Hence, it is important that retail companies keep pace with technological developments and use them to the fullest to become more efficient and effective. Who could have thought that one day drones will be used to make deliveries of retail orders? **EFY**